

Why is the Android OS So Popular?

Discover interesting aspects of the Android OS and get an insight into why it's the most popular today. New OSs like Firefox and Ubuntu are on the horizon, but need to do much more to make a mark.



Android is the most successful mobile operating system in the market today. Let us try and find out whether this success is a product of technical quality or just Google magic. First, let's compare general aspects like security app stores, and hardware support with other smartphone OSs. Then, we will take a look at Android's app development strategy and compare it with that of the Firefox OS. Finally, we will check whether other open source OSs like Firefox OS and Ubuntu Touch could ever overtake or contribute to Android.

History and popularity

Since we have started out saying that Android is the most popular mobile OS, let us define its popularity on a statistical basis.

Android may seem like a recent phenomenon. This is because we have seen Symbian phones around for over a decade since 2000, and Android became a subject of popular interest only after 2010. However, Android is eight years old now (yes, the same as iOS). It is much older if we consider the full history.

Android Inc. was founded in California in October 2003 to develop smarter mobile devices. Google acquired Android

Inc. in July 2005. At Google, an OS based on the Linux kernel was developed after this. The Open Handset Alliance was formed in 2007, and the first smartphone running Android (HTC Dream) was released on October 22, 2008.

However, the fact that both Android and iOS were first released in 2007 gives us one good basis for comparison: how popular is Android compared to another OS of the same age? Well, it turns out that the market share of Android is 82.8 per cent while that of iOS is just 13.9 per cent (Source: International Data Corporation).

One can say that this comparison is inappropriate since iOS is just for Apple phones. The success of iOS depends on a particular device, a situation that Android doesn't face. This situation narrows our comparison to Android vs Windows. Windows Phone, a mobile OS from the creator of the most popular desktop OS, has only a 2.6 per cent market share. We won't analyse other OSs as their shares are below 1 per cent. It is a fact that the latest ones like Firefox OS and Ubuntu still have time to impress us. But they don't seem to have the potential for a quick boost in the near future.

The figures show that Android clearly is the sole ruler among smartphone OSs right now. So let us find out the reasons for this.